THE TIDE ATLAS
Reader’s Companion

Notes on a shoreline that refuses to hold still

Compiled from the keeper’s notebooks, 2019-2026
Published as a read-only archive

This companion belongs with the plates and field notes in the Tide Atlas archive. It is a reading copy: you may download it, print it, and keep it.

The files stay on the keeper’s drive.

Waves at the Edge

There are two ways to keep an archive of a coast. The first is to photograph it, which is a way of saying: this is how it looked, and I was here to see it. The second is to measure it, which is a way of admitting that the photograph was already out of date.

A tide table is not a description of the sea. It is a promise the moon makes to a harbour master, written down in advance so that boats can be loaded and nets mended. When the table says low water at 06:12, it means: be there at 06:12, and the sea will have done its part. Most of the time, it has. The table's usefulness comes from that most.

The sea does not read the table. The table reads the sea, once, and then repeats itself *politely for a year.*

In March 2024 we counted fourteen open anemones in a pool that should have been asleep. The guidebook says they close in winter. The guidebook was written from another coast, by people who had not met these particular anemones.

This is the small, ordinary scandal of field notes: the living thing declines to match the description. A careful archive should record the disagreement, not correct it.

Driftwood Notes

Driftwood is the shore’s mail: everything the sea could not deliver, left at the tide line with no return address. A good beachcombing day is a day when the sea has been sorting.

The rule at the field station: photograph it, note where it was, leave it where it lies. Driftwood belongs to the next high tide, not to us. The archive keeps the photograph and the coordinates; the object keeps its journey.

This is, more or less, how the whole atlas works. We are not collecting the coast. We are keeping a careful record of having noticed it.

A short catalogue of arrivals, 2024

02 March	Pine log, ~2 m	North shingle	No bark; rings suggest old growth
09 March	Trawl float	Estuary mouth	Stamped K-14, unreadable port
17 March	Rope, 3-strand	Ridge path	A bowline, well tied
01 April	Plastic crate	South spit	Used as a seat for the season

End of companion. The archive continues online.